



VANTAGE POINT

Paul Fein



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THE LAST FRONTIER IN TENNIS TECHNIQUE

Paul Fein talks with coach BJ Miller about uncovering flaws in the **split step**, redefining its purpose, and proposing an ideal version to improve reaction and reach.

During tennis' 150-year history, styles have come and gone in a Darwinian survival of the fittest. The Continental game, effective when grass was the predominant court surface and racquets were made of wood, gave way to Eastern stylists. In the 1970s, Bjorn Borg showed that the Western game could win on any surface, as could the two-handed backhand, a potent weapon that Borg, Jimmy Connors, and Chris Evert helped popularise at every level.

Today, with large-headed, graphite racquets turbocharged with polyester strings, world-class players belt balls with astonishing power, topspin, and precision. To keep pace with this unprecedented offence, players have improved their speed, agility, stamina, and overall athleticism.

Yet a little-known student of the game discovered a big flaw in the games of world-class players. BJ. Miller — a retired Ph.D. civil engineer, high school coach, and former No. 6 nationally ranked

Ready for play: [Representative image] A split step in tennis is a small hop most players make just before their opponent hits the ball, landing in a balanced, slightly crouched stance with feet apart (below), allowing them to react and move quickly in any direction. PICS: GETTY IMAGES

senior tournament competitor from Oakland, California — was baffled that these superior tennis athletes couldn't return some shots that seemed within their reach.

Miller suspected the culprit might be the split step.

In this interview, Miller describes his research and what the data and your own eyes reveal. He compares the ideal split step to the one used by almost all high-level players

